

Population Distribution by Ethnic group and Religion

Ethnic group

During the Census of Population and Housing, the ethnic group and religion of all individuals usually resident in the country were reported as declared by the respondents. Identifying the distribution of the population in this manner provides a fundamental understanding of the socio-cultural structure of the country.

Data on ethnic group has been collected in every census conducted since the first national census in 1871. However, different terminologies have been used across various censuses. From 1871 to 1901, the term "Nationality" was used, while in 1911, "Race/Ethnicity" was adopted. Up to 1891, census reports categorized the population under eight major ethnic groups: Sinhalese, Tamil, Moor, Burgher, Eurasian, Malay, European, and Other. In censuses conducted from 1901 to 1971, the Sinhalese ethnic group was subdivided into two categories: "Low Country Sinhalese" and "Up Country Sinhalese" (Kandyan Sinhalese). In subsequent censuses, this sub-classification was removed, and they have since been reported as a single ethnic group, "Sinhalese". Similarly, the Moor ethnic group was subdivided into "Sri Lanka Moor" and "Indian Moor" until 1971. While the Veddhas and European categories were listed separately until 1963, they were included under the "Other" category from 1963 onwards.

At the request of data users, the "Veddhas" ethnic group was reintroduced, and similarly the Indian Tamil ethnic group was further named as Indian Tamil/Malaiyaga Thamilar.

According to the data from the Census of Population and Housing 2024, the distribution of total population by ethnic group in the country is presented in the following table.

Table 6.1.8 : Population Distribution by Ethnic Group, 2024

Ethnicity	Number	Percentage
Sri Lanka	21,781,800	100.00
Sinhalese	16,144,037	74.12
Sri Lanka Tamil	2,681,627	12.31
Indian Tamil/Malaiyaga Thamilar	600,360	2.76
Sri Lanka Moor/Muslim	2,283,246	10.47
Burgher	31,721	0.15
Malay	26,650	0.12
Sri Lanka Chetty	2,443	0.01
Bharatha	1,183	0.01
Veddhas	1,373	0.01
Other	9,160	0.04

According to Table 6.1.8, the Sinhalese represent the largest ethnic group in Sri Lanka, accounting for 74.12 percent of the total population. Sri Lanka Tamils and Sri Lanka Moors/Muslims are reported at 12.31 percent and 10.47 percent, respectively.

Figure 6.1.9 illustrates the distribution of the population by ethnic group. When comparing the percentage distributions of the 2012 and 2024 census years, an increase is observed in the percentages of the Sri Lanka Moor/Muslim and Sri Lanka Tamil ethnic groups while, a percentage decrease is reported for the Indian Tamil/Malaiyaga Thamilar and Sinhalese ethnic groups